

Designing how we work together

Not everything needs collaboration.

Five modes for designing relationships, openness, control, reciprocity, governance and exit.

More isn't better. Choose what the work actually needs.



The archipelago

Five modes. Not stages. You can use several at once, and move between them.

CONNECT

Know, learn, refer, exchange.

COMMONS

Contribute to and steward something others can use.

COLLABORATE

Make and own important things together.

COORDINATE

Adjust what you do around one another.

COOPERATE

Contribute distinct things towards something shared.

NOT A MATURITY MODEL

DESIGN PRINCIPLE

Choose the lightest mode the work needs

The modes differ in how interdependent people are, what has to be shared, and what infrastructure is worth paying for.

CONNECT

We benefit from knowing and learning from one another.

Needs

Useful contact · trust · easy exchange

COORDINATE

We adjust what we do because of what others are doing.

Needs

Visibility · roles · hand-offs · boundaries

COOPERATE

We contribute distinct things towards something shared.

Needs

Outcome · commitments · ownership of pieces

COLLABORATE

We make and own important things together.

Needs

Shared decisions · trust · time · repair

COMMONS

We contribute to and steward something others can use and shape.

Needs

Licences · standards · stewardship · contribution rules

Sometimes a referral is exactly what is needed. Turning it into a “collaboration” would just add meetings.

TWO ORTHOGONAL CHOICES

Design the environment around the mode

Open is not the same as collaborative. Distributed is not the same as open.

HOW OPEN?

Closed

Visible

Participatory

Reusable



Process: open working

Outputs: Creative Commons Software: open source

WHERE DOES CONTROL SIT?

Led

Shared

Federated

Distributed



Central authority can be right. Federation is often useful when people need common rules and local autonomy.

Decentralised ≠ collaborative · Open ≠ decentralised · Reusable ≠ participatory

CONTRIBUTION & RECIPROCITY

What flows between us?

The mode describes how you are relating.
Reciprocity describes what flows.

Reciprocity does not mean equal exchange.

A healthy arrangement can involve very different contributions — as long as they are intentional, understood and reasonably fair.

KNOWLEDGE

TIME

MONEY

LABOUR

ACCESS

RELATIONSHIPS

LEGITIMACY

INFRASTRUCTURE



One-way exchange presented as “collaboration” deserves scrutiny.

GOVERNANCE & PRACTICE

Different modes need different infrastructure

The question is not “how collaborative are we?” but “what do we need to make this mode work well?”

	WHAT IT NEEDS	GOVERNANCE QUESTION	WATCH OUT FOR
CONNECT	Light social infrastructure	Who stays connected? How?	Weak ties disappear when key people leave.
COORDINATE	Information + role infrastructure	Who does what? What needs visibility?	Hidden work, duplication and broken hand-offs.
COOPERATE	Commitment + delivery infrastructure	Who owns which piece? What is promised?	Shared goal, but unequal load or vague accountability.
COLLABORATE	Relational + decision infrastructure	Who can decide? How do we disagree and repair?	One party controls the important choices.
COMMONS	Stewardship + contribution infrastructure	Who can use, change, contribute, maintain or fork?	Open to use, but closed to meaningful influence.

Name the arrangement honestly. A commission, grant, procurement or consultation can be perfectly legitimate without pretending to be collaboration.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

Collaboration and commons are different

You collaborate with people. You contribute to, draw from and steward a commons.

COLLABORATION

Centre of gravity**The relationship****Basic action**

Make + decide together

Dependency

On one another

Infrastructure

Relationships · meetings · decisions · conflict/repair

Power question

Whose voice counts?

Exit

Change, loosen or leave the relationship

COMMONS

Centre of gravity**The shared thing****Basic action**

Contribute · use · steward

Dependency

On the shared resource / infrastructure

Infrastructure

Licences · standards · repositories · documentation · contribution rules

Power question

Who controls the commons?

Exit

Leave · hand over · archive · fork

DIFFERENT INFRASTRUCTURE

CHANGE & EXIT

Every island needs a way off

Design how the relationship can change — before changing it becomes contentious.

FINISH

PAUSE

LEAVE

LOOSEN

DEEPEN

HAND OVER

FORK

CLOSE

How will we know when?

Purpose achieved · conditions changed · costs outweigh value · participation no longer meaningful · another mode now fits better.

Why? Complete · changed · unsustainable · misaligned · unhealthy · evolving

How do we actually do it?

Decision · notice · commitments · data/IP/access · stewardship · communication

For a commons: can it be forked?

WORKSHOP CANVAS

Before you set sail

Use these six questions to design the arrangement — then choose the mode, openness and distribution of control that fit.

1

PURPOSE**What are we actually trying to achieve together?**

What would be different if this worked?

3

DECISIONS**What gets decided together — and what does not?**

Who can commit the organisations involved?

5

OPENNESS & OWNERSHIP**Who can see, use, change and share the work or outputs?**

What should remain private — and why?

2

POWER**Who has money, authority, information and the ability to walk away?**

What power differences need naming or balancing?

4

CONTRIBUTION & RECIPROCITY**What does each participant put in, and what can they draw from?**

What would feel unfair or extractive?

6

CHANGE & EXIT**How will we know when this arrangement should change?**

Who decides, and what happens to the work, money, data and relationships?

Then choose: **MODE · OPENNESS · WHERE CONTROL SITS · WHAT FLOWS · HOW IT CHANGES**